Stand-up
Week 9

Co-Lingo

User Research

What We Learned

1. **Jargon, not language**

   The barrier is workplace-specific phrasing rather than this or 'double-talk' — not an English
   fluency issue.

2. **Privacy protects use**

   People want to ask privately, and repeatedly, without embarrassment or a negative view that they asked.

3. **Timing is everything**

   Support must arrive in the moment. Jargon is forgotten by the time a person can safely ask about it.

4. **Trust needs a backup**

   Users want confidence indicators and a human fallback before acting on anything important.

How We Analyzed It

1. **Thematic Analysis**

Coded every transcript line-by-line across all 3 research rounds, tagging quotes to recurring ideas: embarrassment, speed, jargon type, trust, and inclusion.

2. **Grouping (Affinity Mapping)**

Clustered repeated codes across participants and rounds into higher-level themes, then mapped each theme to a specific design decision for Co-Lingo.

Evidence Behind It

11

participants across 3 research rounds

Baseline interviews → follow-up interviews → Prototype test

"It should make communication easier, not replace the communication between coworkers."

— Prototype test participant Round 2

"I don't want it to be something only international employees use."

— Prototype test participant Round 1

Every finding on this slide traces back to at least one quoted excerpt from the transcripts.

Peer Feedback

What we learned from peer feedback

Peer feedback showed that our concept was still too broad. Several groups questioned whether we were teaching users a language or helping them communicate effectively in the workplace. They also suggested narrowing our target audience and focusing more on real workplace situations, including jargon, social norms, conversations with coworkers and onboarding experiences.

How it changed our prototype

We shifted the prototype from general language learning towards workplace communication practice. The current design focuses on realistic scenarios such as meetings, workplace small talk, asking for clarification and communicating with coworkers. We also introduced a more private practice experience through the robot, allowing users to practise without revealing their language difficulties to colleagues.

What the feedback actually helped us change

Clarified the Main Purpose

Peers questioned whether we were teaching English or supporting workplace communication. We therefore shifted the concept toward practising communication for real workplace situations, rather than general language learning.

Narrowed Our Target Users

Feedback suggested that our audience was too broad. We refined our focus toward international students, graduates and new employees who use English as an additional language in the workplace.

Moved Toward Real Workplace Scenarios

Peers highlighted the importance of jargon, social norms and contextual communication. Our prototype now focuses on situations such as meetings, small talk, asking for clarification and communicating with coworkers or managers.

Created a Private Practice Space

Feedback raised the concern that users may not want coworkers to know they are struggling with communication. This strengthened the role of the robot as a private, low-pressure practice partner before real workplace interactions.

Made the Experience More Interactive

Peers suggested moving beyond one-way language teaching. We developed the prototype around two-way conversations, where users can respond to the robot, receive contextual feedback and practise again.

Experience Requirements

1

What the experience must deliver

1. **Understand in the moment** — Help arrives during/right after the conversation, while the user still remembers what they didn't know
2. **Listen automatically** — The system follows the live conversation and offers help proactively; users "didn't know what to ask"
3. **Keep it private** — Discreet, silent support so the user never looks lost in front of coworkers ("it saves the embarrassment")
4. **Explain in plain language** — Replays jargon-heavy talk in plain words with workplace context
5. **Stay relevant to this workplace** — Explains what terms meant here, not just generic definitions

2

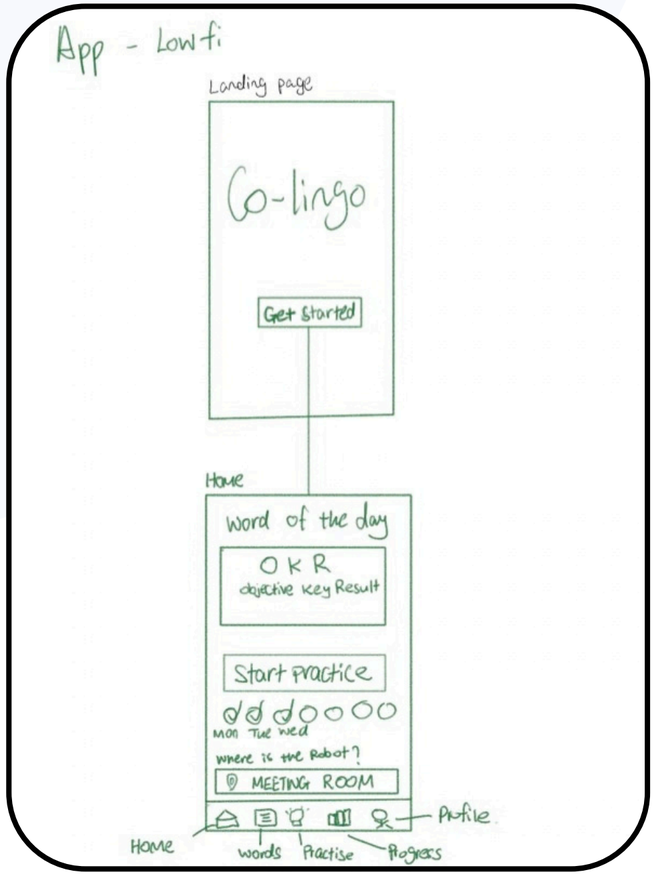
What it must avoid

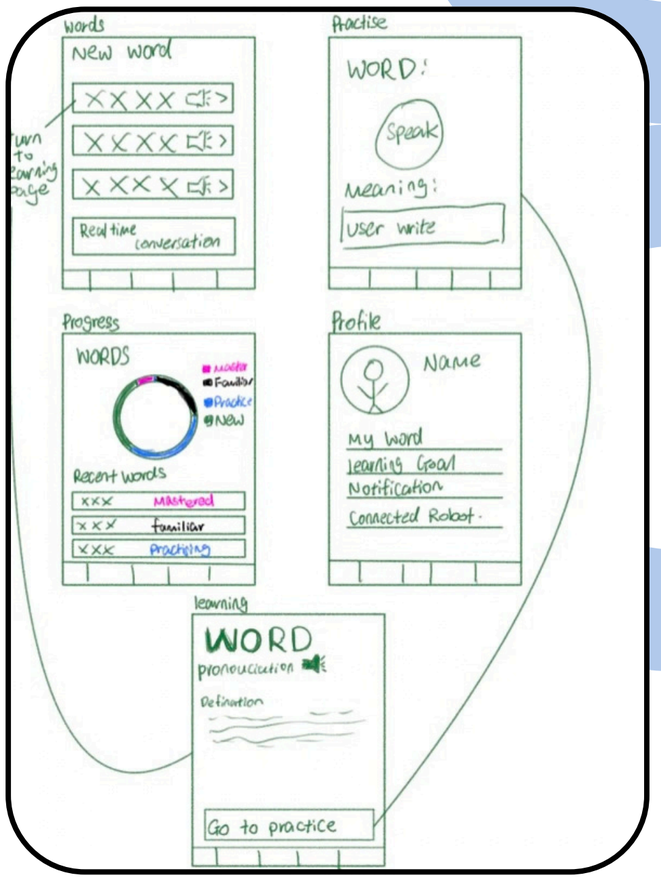
- Manual question-asking afterwards (too slow for fast briefings)
- Public/visible assistance
- Canned, scripted-sounding phrases
- Becoming a crutch during live conversations
- Shifting the teaching burden onto coworkers

Early Prototypes(1)

01 - App Sketches

- Low-fi paper sketches of the Co-Lingo app flow: landing → home → words, practise, progress, profile
- Home: word of the day, daily goal, start practice, streak tracker, robot meeting-room finder
- Practise: speak the word, see its meaning, write your own sentence
- Progress tracks each word as new, practising, familiar or mastered
- Paper testing showed users wanted the daily practice reachable in one tap, so we made "Start practice" the main action on Home

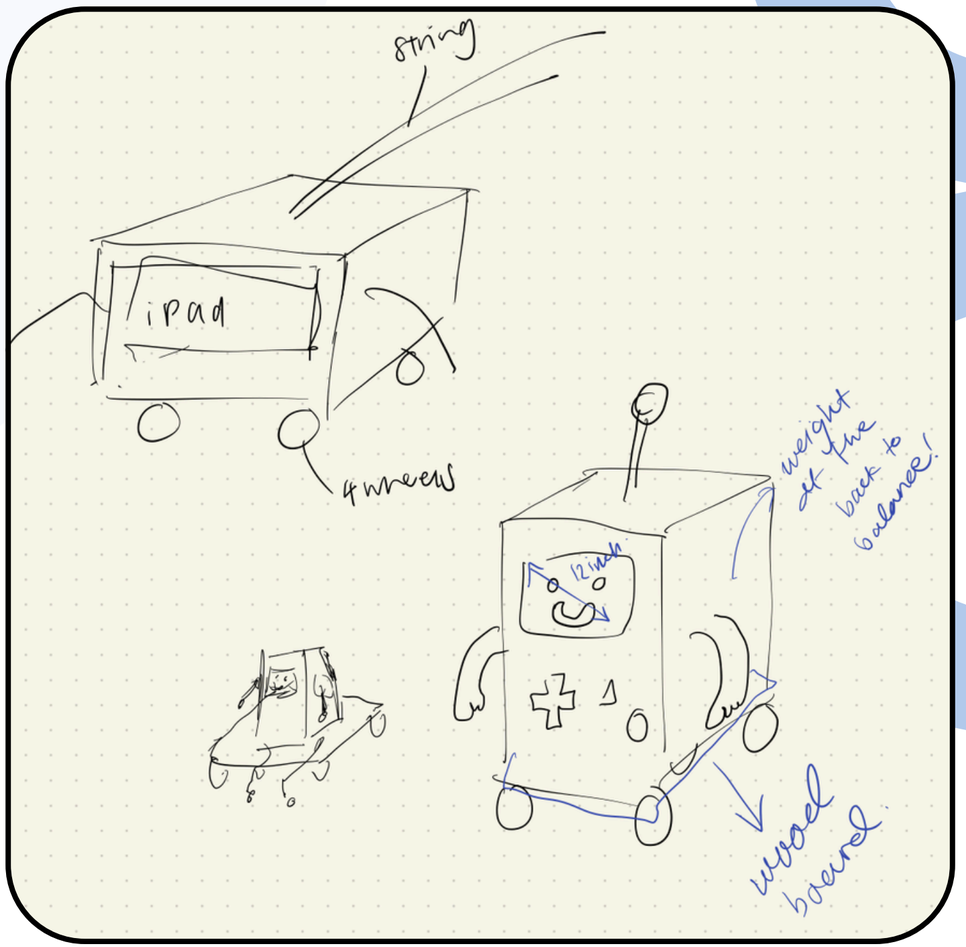




Early Prototypes(2)

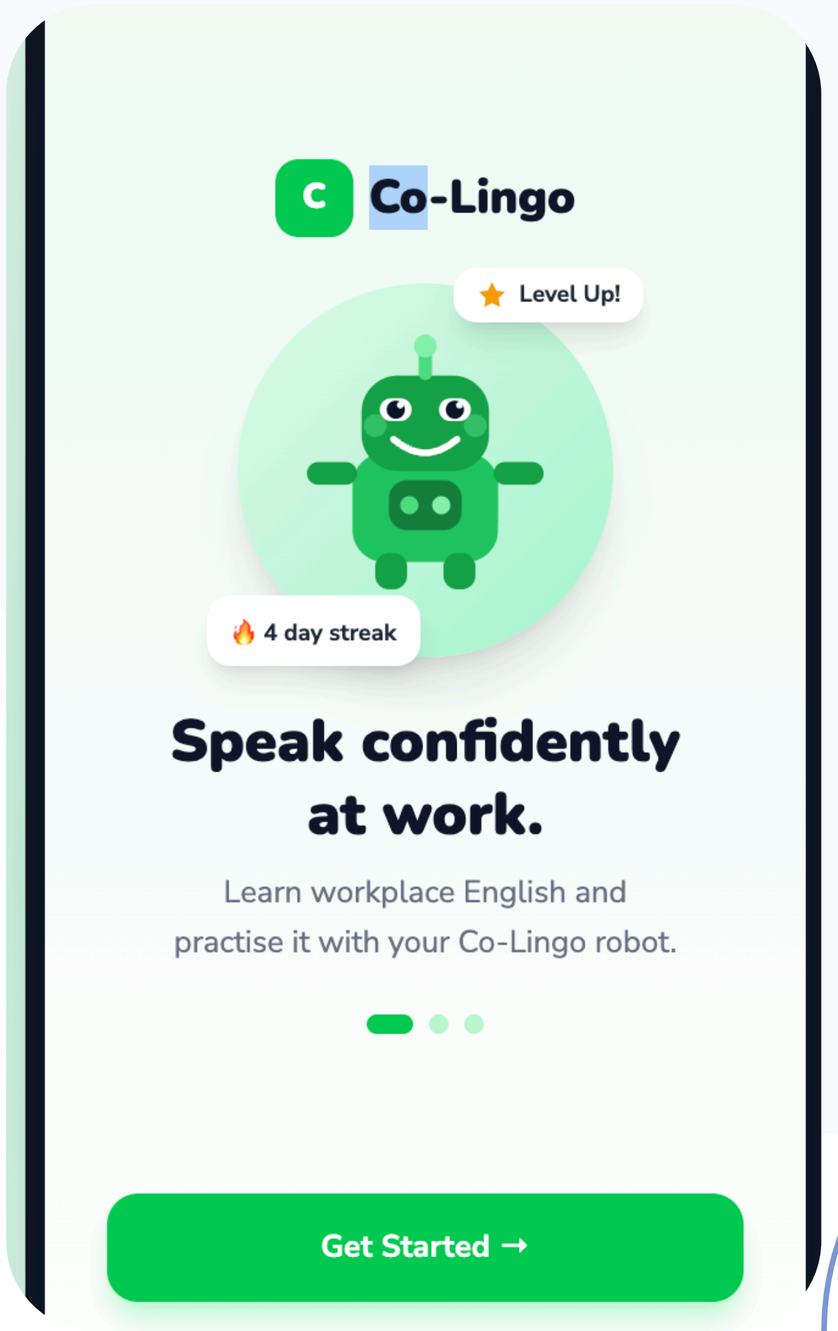
02 - Robot Sketches

- Explored humanoid and wheeled forms, and chose a wheeled box body
- Wheels let the robot move to the worker, and the tablet "face" keeps it friendly and approachable
- Sketches cover four wheels, a tablet display, an antenna and a wooden base board
- Key design questions: weight balance, wheel stability, battery and display placement



Functional Prototype Progress(1)

- Interactive Figma prototype built from the paper sketches: (click here)
- Onboarding sets the message: "Speak confidently at work"
- Streaks and level-ups keep learners motivated
- Robot mascot links the app to the physical robot
- Next: test with users and refine



Functional Prototype Progress(2)

- Physical prototype built: cardboard body, tablet display, wheeled base
- Currently moved by hand with a string attached to the top
- To improve:
  - Balance the robot's weight
  - Decide how it moves: remote-controlled or autonomous
  - Design and build the robot's on-screen interface



TEST PROCEDURE

1. Robot was placed with coworkers and testers
2. Coworker gave a list of things with corporate lingo that the tester needed to note down
3. Tester was given choice to ask coworkers or robot to explain corporate lingo
4. Tester’s list was checked for accuracy and completion





2 Tests Done

POST-TEST FINDINGS

1. Coworkers were first asked for clarification, later on testers stuck to asking the robot for assistance
2. Testers preferred having to ask robot instead of cowokers if they are new to the workplace to avoid being seen as incompetent
3. Testers expressed higher usage if robot looked more hidden in the work place
4. Testers depended on robot for translation while they needed context from coworkers,
5. Robot’s assistance helped the tester understand coworkers better but would prefer if it could do more than just translation.





2 Tests Done

Thank You